

Gestalt Principles Website Critique

1. Effective Example: Apple

Figure-ground

The hero message stands apart from the soft gray background.



College, sorted.

Get a gift card from \$100 to \$150*
when you buy Mac or iPad with
education savings.

Shop

Proximity

The headline, supporting text, and CTA are grouped tightly.



iPhone

Meet the latest iPhone lineup.

Learn more

Shop iPhone

MacBook Air

Now supercharged by M5.

Learn more

Buy

Now supercharged by M4.

Learn more

Buy

MacBook Pro

Now with M5, M5 Pro, and M5 Max.

Learn more

Buy

The ultimate way to
watch your health.

Learn more

Buy

iPad Pro

Advanced AI performance
and game-changing capabilities

Learn more

Buy

Get up to \$205–\$720
in credit when you trade in
iPhone 13 or higher.¹

Get your estimate

Similarity

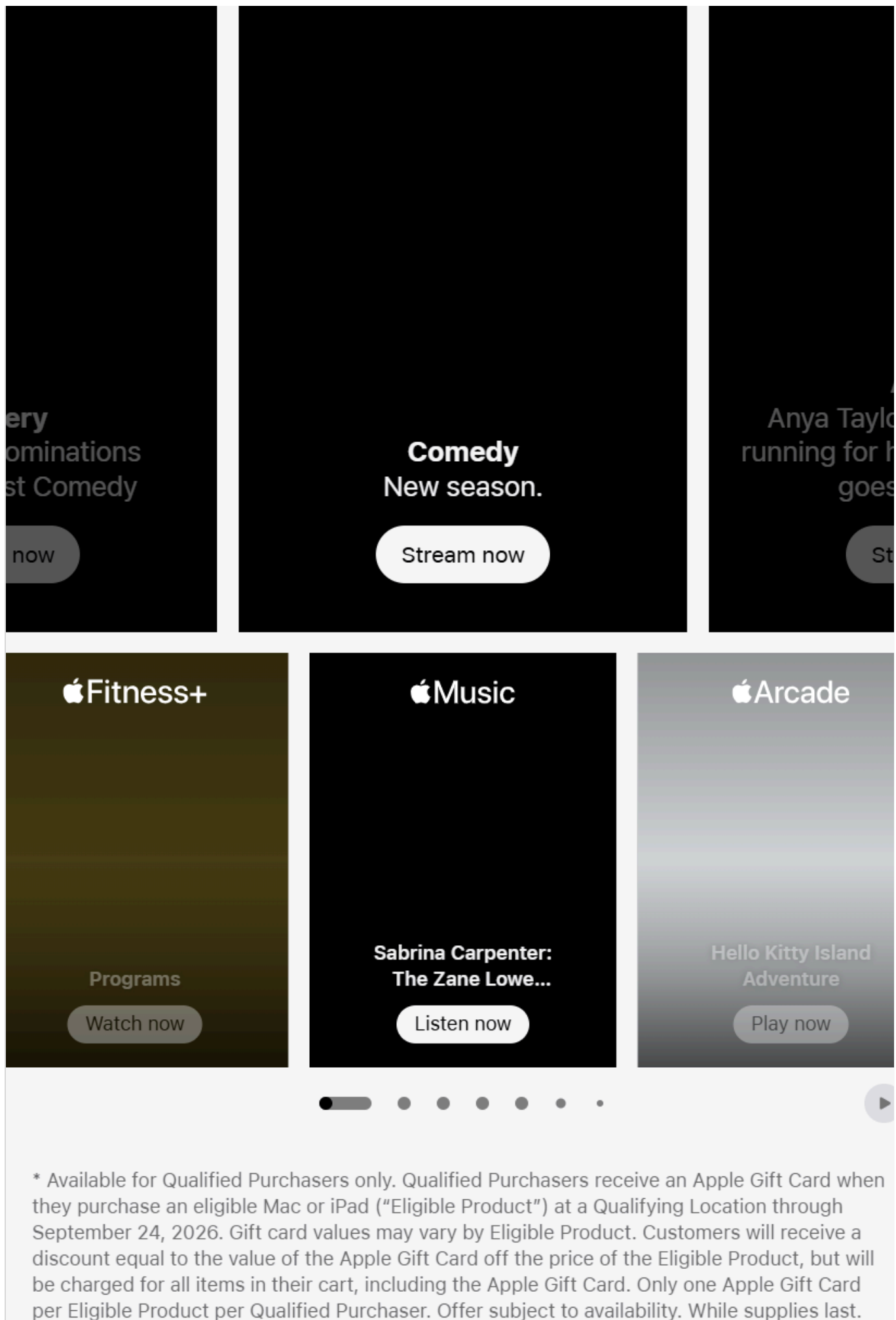
Repeating shape, color, and spacing make the call-to-action feel unified.

Get up to 3% Daily Cash back
with every purchase.

Learn more

Apply now

Endless entertainment.



Additional restrictions apply. View full offer terms [here](#).

1. Trade-in values will vary based on the condition, year, and configuration of your eligible trade-in device. Not all devices are eligible for credit. You must be at least the age of majority to be eligible to trade in for credit or for an Apple Gift Card. Trade-in value may be applied toward qualifying new device purchase, or added to an Apple Gift Card. Actual value awarded is based on receipt of a qualifying device matching the description provided when estimate was made. Sales tax may be assessed on full value of a new device purchase. In-store trade-in requires presentation of a valid photo ID (local law may require saving this information). Offer may not be available in all stores and may vary between in-store and online trade-in. Some stores may have additional requirements. Apple or its trade-in partners reserve the right to refuse, cancel, or limit quantity of any trade-in transaction for any reason. More details are available from Apple's trade-in partner for trade-in and recycling of eligible devices. Restrictions and limitations may apply.

To access and use all Apple Card features and products available only to Apple Card users, you must add Apple Card to Wallet on an iPhone or iPad that supports and has the latest version of iOS or iPadOS. Apple Card is subject to credit approval, available only for qualifying applicants in the United States, and issued by Goldman Sachs Bank USA, Salt Lake City Branch.

Apple Payments Services LLC, a subsidiary of Apple Inc., is a service provider of Goldman Sachs Bank USA for Apple Card and Savings accounts. Neither Apple Inc. nor Apple Payments Services LLC is a bank.

All communications from Apple and Goldman Sachs Bank USA about Apple Card (including transactional and marketing communications) and customer service support are available in English. Certain communications about Apple Card can be viewed in another language depending on your device language settings. If you reside in the U.S. Virgin Islands, American Samoa, Guam, Northern Mariana Islands, or U.S. Minor Outlying Islands, please call Goldman Sachs at 877-255-5923 with questions about Apple Card.

Learn more about how Apple Card applications are evaluated at support.apple.com/kb/HT209218.

A subscription is required for Apple Arcade, Apple Fitness+, Apple Music, and Apple TV.

Features are subject to change. Some features, applications, and services may not be available in all regions or all languages.

Shop and Learn



Apple Wallet



Account

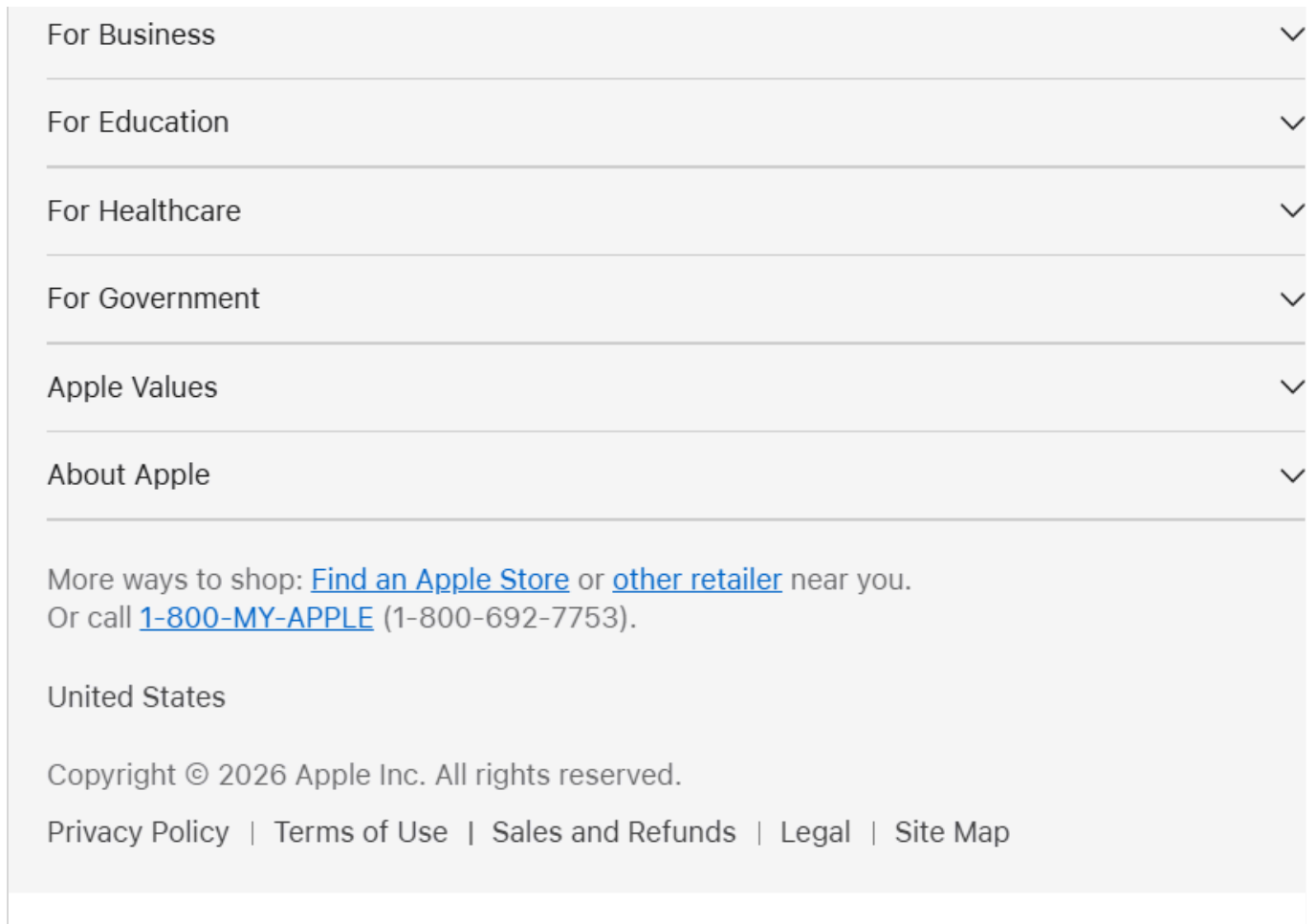


Entertainment



Apple Store



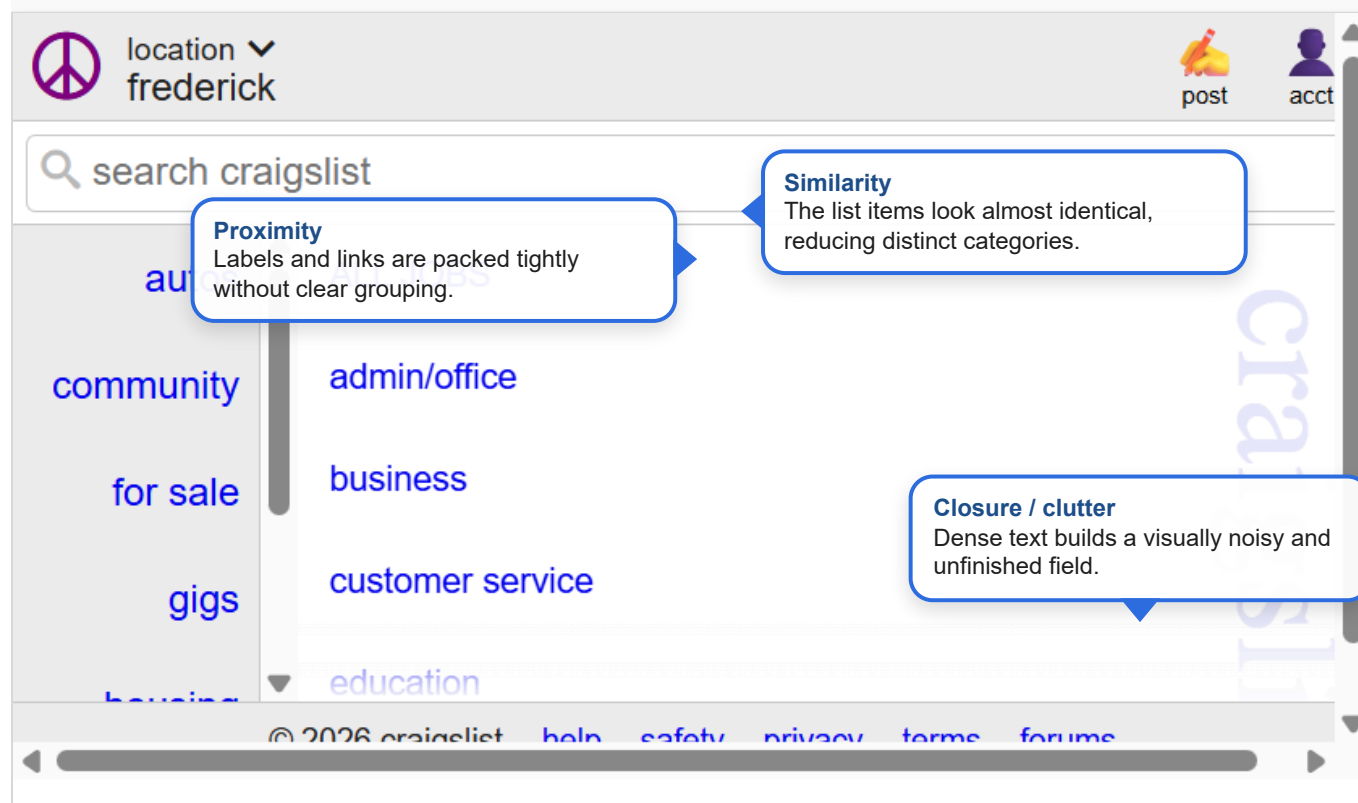


Apple uses Gestalt principles to create a calm, premium shopping experience. The most effective principle is **proximity**: the headline, subheading, and button are placed in a compact visual cluster, which makes the user understand that these elements belong together as one decision point. This reduces cognitive effort because the eye naturally reads the offer as a single message rather than isolated fragments. The space around the hero section also creates a clear figure-ground separation, letting the product message dominate the page while the surrounding gray field acts as a quiet backdrop.

The site also applies **similarity** well. The shop button repeats the same rounded, blue treatment seen in other brand actions, so users quickly understand it as a primary click target. The consistent spacing and typography across the section reinforce hierarchy without clutter. This helps the user experience because the page guides attention smoothly from headline to action, rather than forcing the eye to scan randomly. In practical terms, Apple reduces friction by making the next step obvious and visually consistent.

Overall, the page feels intentional and highly legible. The Gestalt principles support clarity, trust, and motionless focus, which matches Apple's brand and helps users convert without confusion.

2. Weak Example: Craigslist



Craigslist demonstrates how poor use of Gestalt principles can break usability. One major issue is **proximity**. The navigation items, category names, and spacing are compressed into a dense set of text blocks without enough separation, so the eye struggles to tell what belongs together. Instead of grouping logically, the content feels like one long wall of labels. This hurts the user experience because people must work harder to parse where to click and what each cluster is meant to represent.

The site also weakens **similarity**. Many listing categories share the same size, weight, and spacing, so they appear nearly indistinguishable. Because the interface lacks stronger contrast or shape differences, the user cannot quickly scan the page by visual patterns. This reduces efficiency and makes the page feel dated and visually noisy. Similarly, the dense layout undermines closure: the page does not create clear “chunks” of information, so users perceive it as clutter rather than structured content.

The result is a design that is functional but not friendly. The lack of hierarchy and weak grouping makes people search slower and feel less confident about navigation. In a highly task-oriented site, that is a serious usability problem because the user is forced to spend mental energy decoding the layout instead of finding what they need.